because Adham's offerings were still too miserly or because they only confirmed the extent to which Adham had defrauded the treasury, Akbar's 'soul . . . did not open out towards him'.[16]

Indeed, no matter what Adham Khan did to win him over, it 'was not approved of'. When Adham brought out a change of clothes for his guest to wear after the 'dusty ride', Akbar refused. Adham panicked, stumbling 'in the net of agitation', asking others to plead his case until, finally, the padishah 'took compassion on his misery' and relented.[17]

That night, Akbar slept on Adham's roof – a wonderful image, the eighteen-year-old 'stretched out'[18] under the sky on a summer night. Adham didn't sleep a wink. According to Abul Fazl, he lurked about in the hope that Akbar – having travelled without his women – would be tempted to sneak into Adham's harem for the night; such gross violation of protocol would allow Adham to attack the padishah. It isn't clear why Adham might have wanted to kill Akbar, unless he was foolish or enraged enough to imagine that his mother would put him on the Mughal throne in Akbar's place. The idea seems preposterous, but only Akbar could have proposed it to his historian, so perhaps the padishah did feel threatened that night, having ridden with a small guard into hostile terrain. Perhaps that is precisely why he slept on an open roof, avoiding the potential trap of a closed room. It is far from Abul Fazl, of course, to admit any such fear in his hero. Akbar had travelled a long way. 'The last thing on his mind was Adham Khan's gloomy harem,' sniffs the historian.[19] The padishah slept.

The next day, Akbar's own harem arrived, led all the way by Maham Anaka – a woman whose physical strength clearly matched her talent for intrigue. She left later than Akbar yet reached only a day after he did. Maham wasted no time in mending the growing rift between Akbar and Adham, arranging a 'great entertainment' and taking her recalcitrant son in hand, so that Adham finally presented all the tribute he should have before – all the treasure, all the musicians, all the women.[20]

Well . . . not all the women. On 17 May, four days after he had arrived, Akbar left Sarangpur. As was customary, Adham Khan escorted the padishah part of the way, and on the night of their first halt, he had some 'evil thoughts'. Having plotted with some of his mother's servants – Maham ruled the imperial harem – Adham managed to filch two 'special